

Where format tracking stops

A packaging tracking programme I ran for Tetra Pak measured which formats were winning. It could not measure whether the pack worked in someone's hand. This is the learning plan the next decision needed.

PROVENANCE Section one is my own work. Sections four to six are analysis of the public record: disclosed facts and my own inference are labelled separately.

1 · THE PROGRAMME

An annual tracking programme measuring market trends and packaging development across the global liquid beverage industry, run in waves across multiple markets. I built and executed the learning plan, authored the instrument, managed fieldwork through in-country partners and delivered the synthesis. Output fed Tetra Pak's view of where its core format was gaining and losing ground.

WHAT THE INSTRUMENT CAPTURED

Volume sizing and growth Litres by category, prior-year actual against current-year forecast, split ambient and chilled.	Drivers and barriers Top three each per category, probing premiumisation, health positioning and occasion.	Format trend direction Movement toward ambient, chilled, powdered or concentrate, reasoning captured verbatim.
Pack format performance Which formats grew, declined, or were expected to move next, with causal reasoning.	Substrate-level tracking Liquid carton against glass, HDPE and PET, held separately for ambient and chilled.	Investment intent Forward strategy and capital plans, giving the tracker a leading as well as trailing read.

RESEARCH GOVERNANCE

GDPR-compliant consent covering voluntary participation, withdrawal, anonymity in reporting and consent to record.	A classification module routing each respondent only to the category worksheets they were qualified to answer.	Priority question flagging, so interviewers protected core data capture when respondent time ran short.
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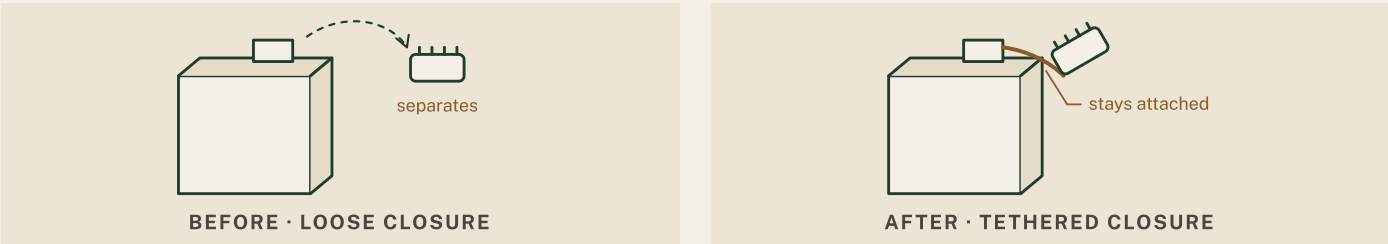
2 · THE LIMIT
Format share is a demand-side signal. It tells you carton is gaining or losing against glass, HDPE and PET, and what manufacturers believe is driving that. It cannot tell you whether a closure opens first time, whether it re-closes on the fourth night, or whether a straw holds up halfway down the glass. Those are experience-side questions, and they need a different instrument.

3 · THE FORCING FUNCTION

Two EU Single-Use Plastics Directive deadlines set the scope of everything that followed: plastic straw bans from July 2021, tethered caps mandatory by July 2024. Tetra Pak moved early on both. This was not discretionary innovation, and a hard deadline across a thousand-plus filling lines changes how consumer learning gets scoped, sequenced and funded.

4 · WHAT SHIPPED, AND WHAT WAS CLAIMED FOR IT

Tetra Pak became the first carton company to launch paper straws in Europe, and in April 2022 launched the world's first tethered caps on carton packages: around €400m in roll-out, over 1,000 lines in scope.



A small geometry change with four separate consumer consequences: opening force, re-closing alignment, clearance at the pour lip, and where spill goes when it fails. Schematic, not to scale.

CONFIRMED · PUBLIC RECORD

At the launch, Tetra Pak's VP Marketing said the caps were designed after collecting consumer insights through multiple pieces of research across various markets, citing **ease of opening, ease of re-closing for subsequent consumption, and carefully sized diameters** for pouring and drinking.

Three claimed benefits, each a measurable construct. The record confirms that research happened, never which methods sat behind it.

5 · THE LEARNING PLAN I WOULD HAVE WRITTEN

BUSINESS QUESTION	CONSTRUCT MEASURED	METHOD	DECISION MILESTONE
Can everyone in the user range open it, first attempt?	Peak opening torque, first-attempt success rate, failure mode	Instrumented usability observation, quotas on grip strength and age, not only category usage	Closure geometry freeze
Will they re-close it, occasion after occasion?	Re-close success rate, leak when stored on its side, cycles to failure	In-home use test, seven days, multiple occasions, real fridge	Go / no-go on tether design
Does the tether interfere with pouring and drinking?	Flow rate, spill incidence, mouth-contact avoidance	Monadic pack test with observed pour, one execution per respondent	Aperture and diameter spec
Does the paper straw change the drink?	Liking delta against the plastic benchmark, off-note incidence, firmness across the occasion	CATA for off-notes, JAR on firmness with penalty analysis, hedonic against benchmark	Straw material sign-off
Does the converted pack still get found on shelf?	Fixation latency, dwell, share of choice	Eye-tracking against a simulated aisle of unconverted competitors	The conversion case put to brand owners

6 · THE METHOD I WOULD HAVE ARGUED HARDEST FOR

Re-closing for subsequent consumption is an in-home, multi-occasion behaviour, and a central location test structurally cannot see it. The fridge, the carton stored on its side, the fourth open-and-close of the week all happen somewhere a sixty-second CLT never reaches.

CONFIRMED · INDEPENDENT STUDY

A DIN Consumer Council usability study found none of the tethered cap systems fully convinced consumers. The system used on Tetra Pak packs rated relatively easy to open but harder than alternatives for pouring, drinking and above all re-closing. Children, elderly and manually impaired participants met spills and injuries.

That tension is instructive rather than damning. A programme with that budget still shipped a closure an independent study later criticised on exactly the benefit its own launch language claimed. The plausible reasons are ones any of us can design around: learning weighted toward acceptance rather than instrumented usability, sample frames that never deliberately recruited manual impairment or older users, and protocols that under-detect a failure which only appears on repeat occasions at home.

This presentation contains reconstructed project examples for portfolio purposes. No confidential client data, proprietary insights, or sensitive materials are included.

SOURCES Sections 1–3 from my own project files, with client detail limited to what is publicly attributable. Sections 4 and 6 from Tetra Pak and Tetra Laval press releases, trade press, the DIN Consumer Council usability study of tethered caps, and sensory literature on straw material effects and CLT versus HUT divergence. Section 5 and both schematics are my own.